STIVEN CATALYST

FIRST SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



STRATEGY

WHO DECIDES WHAT

Why decisions get stuck between people rather than for lack of information, four kinds of decisions, and five roles that make clear who has the final word.

20% of respondents said their organisation excels at decision making. Only 48% said it decides quickly.

MCKINSEY, 2019

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NO. 08 · STRATEGY

In this issue

Many decisions run late even when the data are there, because nobody knows who decides. Hence the theme of this issue, decision rights: who proposes, who gives input and who has the final word.

In a McKinsey survey of 1,259 respondents, only one in five said their organisation makes decisions excellently. In 2017 McKinsey had sorted decisions into four kinds, each with its own way of deciding. And in 2006 Paul Rogers and Marcia Blenko proposed five roles that make clear who has the final word.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

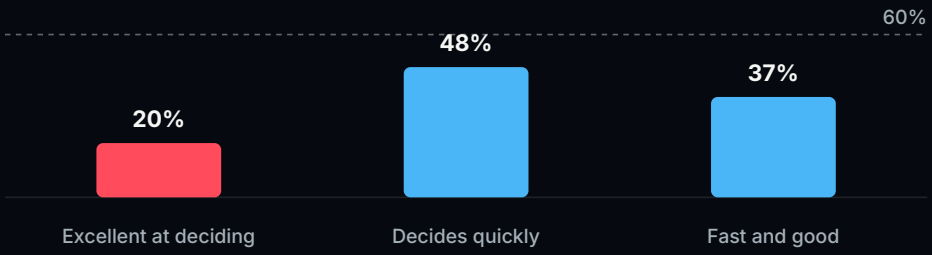
COVER STORY

Speed does not spoil quality

Many organisations behave as if fast decisions were rushed decisions. McKinsey's 2019 survey found the opposite.

Only 48% of respondents said their organisation decides quickly, and 37% that its decisions are both fast and good. But those who decided quickly were twice as likely to report high-quality decisions. Speed and quality moved together, not against each other. These are the respondents' own assessments, collected in February 2018.

WHAT RESPONDENTS SAID ABOUT THEIR ORGANISATION



Share of 1,259 respondents to a McKinsey survey, February 2018. Their own assessments of their organisation.

2×
as often, fast deciders reported high-quality decisions

1,259
respondents, February 2018

OUR READING

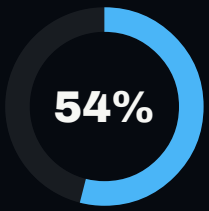
When a decision keeps waiting, ask who owns it. Often the answer is nobody.

Source: McKinsey & Company, 2019 (via Excerpts, through web search)

THE NUMBERS

The time that goes to waste

Over half of respondents spend over 30% of their time on decisions. Most said at least half of it is wasted.



of respondents spend over 30% of their working time on decisions (McKinsey, 2019).

Share of respondents to a McKinsey survey (2019). Their own estimate of the time they spend, not a measurement.

61%
say at least half of their decision time is wasted

530,000
manager days a year at a typical Fortune 500 company, in a McKinsey calculation

$250m
in wages for those days

The calculation is a thought experiment, with nothing measured: it assumes a company of about 56,000 employees, 20% of them managers who spend 37% of their time on decisions.

OUR READING

Most of the lost time sits in meetings where nobody knows whether they are there to decide or to advise.

Sources: McKinsey & Company, 2019 (via Excerpts, through web search); McKinsey Quarterly, 2019

THE MODEL

Four kinds of decisions

Aaron De Smet, Gerald Lackey and Leigh Weiss (McKinsey, 2017) sorted decisions by how often they come and how much risk they carry. Each kind needs a different way of deciding.

RISK

Big bets Few, but they shape the future. Leaders decide, after an open debate. HIGH RISK · RARE	**Cross-cutting** Pricing, new products. Several functions decide together, with a clear process. HIGH RISK · FREQUENT
Ad hoc Rare and low-risk. The authors set them aside on purpose. LOW RISK · RARE	**Delegated** Everyday decisions. One person or a small team takes them, without much consultation. LOW RISK · FREQUENT

HOW OFTEN THEY COME

OUR READING

Many small decisions get stuck because they are treated as big ones: everyone is asked, but nobody decides.

Source: Aaron De Smet, Gerald Lackey & Leigh M. Weiss, McKinsey Quarterly, 2017 (via Summary by the same authors in “Three keys” (2019))

The descriptions in the cells are our summary of the 2017 article.

More in the essay When to solve it yourself and when to take it higher

THE ROLES

Who has the “D”?

Paul Rogers and Marcia Blenko (Bain, 2006) proposed five roles for every important decision. The name comes from their initials: RAPID.

01	**Recommend (R)**	Gathers the facts, hears the input and makes the proposal.
02	**Agree (A)**	Must sign off and can stop the proposal. Used sparingly.
03	**Perform (P)**	Puts the decision into practice once it is made.
04	**Input (I)**	Is consulted on facts and risks, but does not decide.
05	**Decide (D)**	One person has the final word and closes the matter.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, OVERTIME IN A WAREHOUSE
> The shift lead recommends, with the order numbers. HR agrees, as far as the working-time rules are concerned. The team gives input on who is available. The operations manager decides. The shift lead and the team perform.

According to the authors, decisions get stuck most often at four borders: between headquarters and units, between global and local, between functions, and between the company and outside partners. The roles are not played in the order of the letters.

OUR READING

A meeting without a “D” ends with “we will see”.

Source: Paul Rogers & Marcia Blenko, Harvard Business Review, 2006

HOW IT IS MEASURED

The decision map

Pick the ten decisions your team takes most often and ask for each: who decides? Then ask the team.

1. **List ten decisions**
   The recurring ones: who works overtime, when an order goes back, who swaps a shift.
2. **Write who decides**
   In your view, for each one.
3. **Ask the team separately**
   Without showing them your answers.
4. **Compare**
   Where the answers differ, the work gets stuck. Start with that decision.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, TEN DECISIONS IN A SHIFT
> The lead and the team agree on six. On the other four, two people think they decide themselves, and nobody knows who decides on shift swaps. (The numbers are invented.)

OUR READING

The question “who decides?” looks bureaucratic only until an order waits two days for an answer.

Steps and example by the editors.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The decision card

For every decision that has been stuck for more than a week. Fill it in before the meeting, not after.

01 The decision what, and by when

02 Recommends who prepares the proposal

03 Agrees who must sign off, if anyone

04 Gives input whom we ask, about what

05 Decides one role

06 Performs and informs who carries it out, who needs to know

An editors' practice, modelled on the RAPID roles. Names and confidential data do not belong on the card.

Open the tool: Shift Handover stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-handover/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Decision making in the age of urgency
McKinsey & Company, 2019 · via Excerpts, through web search
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/decision-making-in-the-age-of-urgency

Three keys to faster, better decisions
McKinsey Quarterly, 2019
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/three-keys-to-faster-better-decisions

Untangling your organization's decision making
Aaron De Smet, Gerald Lackey & Leigh M. Weiss, McKinsey Quarterly, 2017 · via Summary by the same authors in "Three keys" (2019)
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/untangling-your-organizations-decision-making

Who Has the D? How Clear Decision Roles Enhance Organizational Performance
Paul Rogers & Marcia Blenko, Harvard Business Review, 2006
https://hbr.org/2006/01/who-has-the-d-how-clear-decision-roles-enhance-organizational-performance

CORRECTION · 12 OCTOBER 2026

The large figure on the time spent on decisions is now 54% of respondents who spend over 30% of their working time on them, as McKinsey reports it; the issue first gave 37% of working time, a figure McKinsey uses only as an assumption in its cost calculation.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked "via". A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked "Our reading".



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html